

“Consumers want to associate with environment-friendly products”



Japanese consumer electronics manufacturer Panasonic is one company implementing the green initiative quite seriously in India. It plans to become the No. 1 green innovation company in the electronics industry by 2018. And as part of its global campaign, it will reach out to its customers in India for recycling of electronic items.

Manish Sharma, director-marketing, Panasonic India, speaks to Uma Bansal, executive editor at EFY, about the urgency for going environment-friendly and green design practices that could be followed. Excerpts...

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For electronics manufacturers, how important is it today to become environment-friendly in their products and operations?

Green production is a business strategy that focuses on profitability through environment-friendly operating processes. Proponents of this management philosophy believe that green production is a sensible course to follow not only because of the benefits it bestows on the environment but also because of its fundamental strategic soundness.

Manufacturers are being motivated to go green by spiraling energy costs, growing concerns about the future of non-renewable resources, surging consumer demand for eco-friendly products and processes and environmental sustainability.

As there has been a mounting pressure from green watchdogs, how successful have been companies in phasing out toxics from their products?

The greatest environmental challenge facing our industry today is the presence of toxic substances such as arsenic, brominated flame retardants, mercury, phthalates and polyvinyl chloride in products. Although most countries still allow use of these substances, companies are working with their manufacturing partners to eliminate them from products. We all have to understand that designing greener products means considering the environmental impact of the materials used to make them. From the glass, plastic and

metal in our products to the paper and ink in our packaging, our goal is to reduce or eliminate environmentally harmful substances.

Panasonic, in general, feels that a concerted effort needs to be undertaken for drastic GHG emission reduction and innovative technological development must be achieved in a timely manner to tackle global warming and stabilise the GHG concentration.

What challenges do they face while going green?

As the world's population grows, the living standards improve and the economies develop, the biggest global challenge is to do all this in a sustainable manner instead of impacting the environment.

Many organisations want to turn green as an increasing number of consumers want to associate themselves with environment-friendly products. Green technology requires constant R&D and innovation. Firms cannot aspire to be flexible if they did not innovate. Continuous innovations in terms of product and marketing strategies will raise the stature of the organisation in the market.

Yet, while companies are trying to meet this need, a very serious challenge is on the consumer side, as many distrust the credibility of green products. Therefore to ensure consumer confidence, marketers of green products need to be much more transparent and refrain from breaching any law or standard relating to products or business practices.